

International Mediation and Political Bargaining in the Cuban Missile Crisis

Why did the Cuban missile crisis not lead to a nuclear war?

The Cuba missile crisis (CMC) is the closest moment to a nuclear war in human history, which occurred from 16 October to 28 October in 1962. There are heated debates among scholars about why the CMC did not lead to a nuclear war. Many classic studies of the CMC focus on the interactions between the Soviet Union and America, such as contrast of their military power (Allison and Zelikow, 1999), personality of the leadership in the Kennedy administration (Gibson, 2012). However, some scholars point that some international organizations play a role (Dorn and Pauk, 2009; Keller, 2019), while the political deals of superpowers are also important (Pious, 2001). This essay argues that the roles of international organizations and the political deals between American-Soviet Union are prominent factors for the successful resolution in the CMC. Firstly, it would discuss the functions of the Organization of America States (OAS) and the United Nations (UN). Then, it will demonstrate how the political deals may solve the crisis. Thirdly, some opposite perspectives will be shown.

Some international organizations such as the OAS and the UN played a positive role, which release the peaceful information giving a negotiating space for superpowers. The OAS gives legitimacy to America's dangerous blockade, spreading a signal that America do not willing to launch military action firstly. If America directly blockades (usually called quarantine) Cuba, the Soviet Union might misinterpret this as a hostile act (Keller,2019). According to a memorandum from McCone (1962), America considers the Rio Pact would offer the legal requirements of blockade, avoiding "declaration of war against Cuba". Besides, Rusk (1962), the secretary of state, appealing OAS "agreeing that the governments of the Hemisphere should take all actions they may deem necessary against Cuba as provided for in Article 8 of the Rio Pact" to all Latin American states. In this way, America reduces the risk of blockade action through appeal OAS. Also, it shows its aggressiveness towards Cuba, threatening the further military action. It gives the Soviet Union a time to concern this issue. Besides, the UN eases the tensions atmosphere for mediating the crisis. For example, U Thant, the Secretary General of the UN, emphasizes that if America could guarantee Cuba's territorial integrity,

this may reach a deal of withdrawing missiles (Dorn and Pauk, 2009). Actually, America agrees this proposal then pronounces it would not invade Cuba in public that afternoon (Dorn and Pauk, 2009). Moreover, Khrushchev (1974) argues due to this action, the Soviet Union consider the withdrawal. The reason why the Soviet Union may set missile is protect Cuba national security. That achieves a political deal for America would not invade Cuba. In the CMC, any small conflict would enable a huge misunderstanding, enhancing the crisis losing of control. Though the OAS and the UN may be ignored in many researches, they play an important role in the CMC.

The political deals done by superpowers enhances the peaceful solution. The withdrawal could protect America national security while stabling domestic politics. According to the National Security Council (1962), Cuba had sixteen SS-4 missiles, which could launch 1020 nautical miles directly pointing the central area of the US. Moreover, Secretary of Defence Robert McNamara called the CMC as a political issue and president Kennedy believes he will not be impeached only if the crisis is resolved peacefully (Pious, 2001). From America side, external and internal environment required a peaceful solution for this crisis. The compromise of America meets the Soviet Union demands. The Soviet Union already gets what it wants--the security for Cuba and the balance of the nuclear power. When Khrushchev (1971) recalls about the CMC, he argues protecting Cuba is their only purpose. Meanwhile, the Soviet Union complains about the disbalanced of nuclear power between superpowers (Allison, 1999). With increasing danger and misunderstanding during the crisis, both sides government realize it is time to a concession. The OAS and the UN have given them enough room to reach compromises that are acceptable for them. In order to protect their national interest, the political deals enable them to ignore some puzzling actions during the thirteen days, such as the Soviet Union wrecked a U-2 reconnaissance aircraft from America, the U-2 reconnaissance aircraft flew into the territory of the Soviet Union and so on. If keeping this intensive situation, it will out of control. It is rational that when they get interest then stop the crisis.

However, some argue that the interaction and strength contrast between superpowers enhances the peaceful solution. Allison (1999) argues that America was stronger than the Soviet Union from strategical and tactical sides at that time. The rising military threats from America is the main reason for withdrawal (Allison, 1999). Kennedy administration has to come up with a plan to avoid potential nuclear war while protecting its national security of long-term (Galinsky and Schweitzer, 2016). President Kennedy needs to protect America

international reputation and his domestic prestige, so some international organizations could be involved during the CMC. According to the stronger military power of America, the Soviet Union may face a failure if they have a nuclear war. Thus, even without the organizations, the Soviet Union may withdraw the missile then the CMC may be peacefully solved. Though it makes sense, the information and orders would be mis-expressed in the tense crisis, which could accidentally lead to missiles launched. For example, although the U-2 reconnaissance aircraft was destroyed by mistake, Khrushchev did not order that action. When the son of Khrushchev records this, he (2000) points that his father was satisfied with the wreck, but there was deep disquiet. Moreover, there were some troops still “obeyed Castro’s (the chairman of Cuba) command to ‘destroy any foreign plane which appears over the island’.” even after Khrushchev had forbidden not to have any military action (Khrushchev, 2000, p.615). This could demonstrate that the information was easily misunderstood during the CMC. If there are no OAS and UN to negotiate, no reach timely political deals, Khrushchev would not withdraw the missile on 28 October. Any small event could be misinterpreted as an act of declaration of war. Therefore, the function of international organizations and the timely political deals help states avoid the greatest tragedy in human history.

In conclusion, some international organizations act as the mediators in the crisis, releasing positive signals, besides, the timely political deals prevent the CMC from escalating. They all contributed to not lead to a nuclear war.

References

- Allison, G. T. & Zelikow, P., 1999. *Essence of decision: explaining the Cuban missile crisis*. 2nd ed. New York: Longman.
- Dorn, A. Walter & Pauk, R., 2009. *Unsung Mediator: U Thant and the Cuban Missile Crisis*. *Diplomatic history*. [Online] 33 (2), 261–292.
- Gibson, D. R., 2012. Decisions at the brink. *Nature (London)*. [Online] 487 (7405), 27–29.
- Keller, R., 2019. ‘Responsibility of the Great Ones’: How the Organization of American States and the United Nations Helped Resolve the Cuban Missile Crisis. *Journal of Latin American studies*. [Online] 51 (4), 883–904.
- Khrushchev, N. S. and Crankshaw, E., 1971. *Khrushchev remembers*. Vol.2. *The last testament*. London: Deutsch.
- Khrushchev, S., 2000. *Nikita Khrushchev: Creation of a Superpower*. Pennsylvania: Pennsylvania State University Press
- National Security council, 1962. *Minutes of the 505th Meeting*. October 20, 1962. Washington. Available at: https://avalon.law.yale.edu/20th_century/msc_cuba034.asp#b5 [Accessed 18 November 2021]

McCone, John A., 1962. "Memorandum from McCone to USIB members". October 19, 1962. Available at: <https://history.state.gov/historicaldocuments/frus1961-63v10-12mSupp/d338> [Accessed 18 November 2021]

Pious, R. M., 2001. The Cuban Missile Crisis and the Limits of Crisis Management. *Political science quarterly*. [Online] 116 (1), 81–105.

Rusk, H. A., 1962. Circular telegram 700 to all Latin American posts. October 21, 1962. Available at: <https://history.state.gov/historicaldocuments/frus1961-63v10-12mSupp/d349> [Accessed 18 November 2021]